

Policy Brief: UNHCR Response To The Syrian Refugee Crisis

April 2025

PURPOSE OF THE BRIEFING

Refugees International is deeply concerned by the unstable and vulnerable position of Syrian refugees in light of the continually evolving political situation in Syria. The situation is incredibly complex and sensitive, exacerbated by broader tensions in the Middle Eastern region and great power interest in the political leadership of Syria after the fall of the Assad regime. This crisis is largely unique and unprecedented, providing the UNHCR with a similarly unique opportunity to set a precedent of comprehensive and compassionate policies to deal with crises in which vulnerable individuals risk refoulement due to instability and uncertainty of their status as refugees.

As such, Refugees International aims to:

1. Promote the safe, voluntary return of Syrian refugees
2. Protect the rights and livelihoods of these refugees in their current host countries
3. Facilitate the stability of the political, economic and humanitarian situation in Syria

OVERVIEW OF THE CURRENT STATUS OF THE REFUGEE CRISIS

With over 6 million refugees overseas and another 7 million internally displaced¹, the Syrian refugee crisis is one of the largest in the world. The fall of the Assad regime in December 2024 (13 years after the crisis began) threatens the security of these 14 million individuals' statuses as refugees, with European countries calling and pushing for the return of Syrian refugees² and halting asylum claims³. Legal vulnerability and an unstable, impoverished and volatile political situation in Syria⁴ (745 civilians killed in political clash in early March 2025⁵) places refugees at risk of harm if they are pressured to return prematurely or refouled. Refugees International calls for the long-term protection of these refugees given their current legal, economic and political vulnerabilities.

POLICY OPTION 1 – ENHANCED PROTECTION OF REFUGEES

Urgent action is necessary to safeguard refugee rights abroad, prevent involuntary returns and refugees being forced 'in the shadows'⁶. Therefore, refugee status should be guaranteed for at least 18 months and reviewed every 6 months and pauses in asylum seeking applications should be stopped. More programmes, like the UK's Syrian Vulnerable Persons Resettlement Scheme (VPRS)⁷, should be developed to allow refugees to seek permanent residence in their current host countries, once they meet the required criteria. Finally, a process of integration should be developed within these countries based on incentives to facilitate access to social support, education, healthcare, employment, housing assistance and citizenship. This could also be achieved by building the capacity of existing social support services, engagement with NGOs, local volunteer organisations and initiatives at all levels.

- Advantages: This policy option will secure the protection of refugee rights and safety abroad. It will also reduce uncertainty about legal status, protect refugees' agency and allow them to make definite, informed decisions, thus laying the foundation for the repatriation programme. It will avoid

¹ UNHCR (2024). *Syria Refugee Crisis Explained*. [online] Unrefugees.org. Available at: <https://www.unrefugees.org/news/syria-refugee-crisis-explained/>. (Accessed 21 March 2025)

² Bernild, M. (2023). 'Syrian Refugees in Denmark at Risk of Forced Return', *Human Rights Watch*, November 2021 [online]. Available at: <https://www.hrw.org/news/2023/03/13/syrian-refugees-denmark-risk-forced-return> (Accessed 21 March 2025); Menendez-Roche, M. (2024). 'Italy, Denmark, and allies push bold Syrian repatriation plan'. *Euro Weekly News*, December 2024 [online]. Available at: <https://euroweeklynnews.com/2024/12/19/italy-denmark-and-allies-push-bold-syrian-repatriation-plan/> (Accessed 31 Mar. 2025).

³ Shankar, P. (2024). 'Why is Europe pausing Syrian asylum claims after al-Assad's fall?', *Al Jazeera*, December 2024 [online]. Available at: <https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2024/12/10/why-is-europe-pausing-syrian-asylum-claims-after-al-assads-fall> (Accessed 16 Mar. 2025).

⁴ D'Alessandra, F. (2025). *The Fears and Hopes of Bashar al-Assad's Victims*. [online] *International Crimes Accountability Matters in PostAssad Syria*, Carnegie Endowment for International Peace, pp.2–4. doi:<https://doi.org/10.2307/resrep67320.4>.

⁵ Christou, W. (2025). *More than 1,000 people killed in two days of clashes in Syria, war monitor says*. [online] the Guardian. Available at: <https://www.theguardian.com/world/2025/mar/09/more-than-1000-people-killed-in-two-days-of-clashes-in-syria-war-monitor-says>.

⁶ Secen, S. (2020). 'Explaining the Politics of Security: Syrian Refugees in Turkey and Lebanon'. *Journal of Global Security Studies*, 6(3): 18. <https://doi.org/10.1093/jogss/ogaa039>.

⁷ UK Visas and Immigration (2021). 'Vulnerable Persons and Vulnerable Children's Resettlement Schemes Factsheet', *UK Visas and Migration*, March 2021 [online]. Available at: <https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/uk-resettlement-schemes-factsheet-march-2021/vulnerable-persons-and-vulnerable-childrens-resettlement-schemes-factsheet-march-2021> (Accessed 18 Mar. 2025).

unnecessarily uprooting the lives of those already integrated in host countries and could even facilitate further integration of refugees currently living in unstable or uncertain conditions abroad.

- Limitations: This policy option may lead to pressures from citizens of host countries in which anti-immigration sentiments are prevalent, which could lower the likelihood of successfully implementing pathways for refugees to access permanent residency. Moreover, extra effort will be needed to maintain sound cooperation between the UN, local NGOs and the Syrian government.

POLICY OPTION 2 – FACILITATING THE BUILDING OF NEW INFRASTRUCTURE

Repairing key infrastructure and services such as water, electricity, roads, and hospitals needs to be prioritised to provide a basis for stability and security upon the elective return of Syrian refugees. Furthermore, reconstruction funds should be invested into capacity-building endeavours, such as vocational training in fields like construction to provide Syrians with steady employment and reintegration, alongside building essential infrastructure. Both initiatives can be financed through continued support from actors such as the EU, who estimate their financial requirement be around €163,000,000/yr⁸ based on data from 2024, and international collaboration and coordination between states; the transitional Syrian government; NGOs; and the UN is key to be effective given the complex nature of the crisis.

- Advantages: This policy option addresses the situation in the long term, ensuring that Syrian refugees can return to a safe and stable environment, which will increase the likelihood of refugees returning to Syria and, consequentially, reduce pressure on host states. Moreover, building infrastructure will allow stability to be self-sustaining, over time allowing actors to reduce and potentially cease funding to both Syrian refugees, as they are repatriated, and Syria itself, as its infrastructure develops.
- Limitations: This option requires more funding to rebuild infrastructure alongside humanitarian aid. It might prove difficult to convince states and private investors to do this amid uncertainty, and could lead to donor fatigue⁹, especially considering the funding shortfall already amounted to \$1.1 billion in 2024, just 41% of what was required by the UNHCR¹⁰. Additionally, collaboration between different types of actors may prove difficult, and the long-term nature of the project may result in impatience, frustration, and potential lapses or loss of funding. Finally, Syria's needs and social fabric is different region by region, so infrastructure solutions must be specifically tailored, requiring substantive planning and time commitment.

POLICY OPTION 3 – REFORM OF THE REPATRIATION PROCESS

Establishing a clear, transparent and streamlined process by which those wishing to return can be re-settled is imperative. Such process should focus on access to legal aid and return assistance facilitated by the UN, and the continuation of "go-and-see" scheme¹¹, which allow Syrian refugees to visit home for a short period of time to inform their decisions regarding their potential return and have proven useful previously, as exemplified by the Rwandan repatriation¹². This will require to further support and oversee the collaboration between countries, particularly neighbouring ones, with the Syrian government itself. In addition, there is a need to end all initiatives and programmes that promote returns through economic incentives (Austria and Cyprus¹³) which create barriers to successful repatriation through short-term solutions that can lead to refugees having to flee again due to instability or to the perpetuation of precarious conditions inside Syria caused by sudden and uniformed decisions.

⁸ European Commission (2020). *Syria*. [online] civil-protection-humanitarian-aid.ec.europa.eu. Available at: https://civil-protection-humanitarian-aid.ec.europa.eu/where/middle-east-and-northern-africa/syria_en. (Accessed 18 Mar. 2025)

⁹ Zeager, L.A. and Bascom, J.B. (1996). 'Strategic Behavior in Refugee Repatriation: A Game Theoretic Analysis', *The Journal of Conflict Resolution*, 40(3), pp.460–485: 475. <https://doi.org/10.2307/174315>.

¹⁰ UNHCR (2024). *Syria: Global Appeal 2025 Situation Overview*. [online] The UN Refugee Agency. Available at: <https://reporting.unhcr.org/sites/default/files/2024-11/Syria%20Situation%20Overview%20v4.pdf> (Accessed 6 Mar. 2025).

¹¹ Zayadin, H. (2025). EU, Other Host States Should Support Syrians Weighing Return with 'Go-and-See' Visits. *Human Rights Watch*, December 2024 [online]. Available at: <https://www.hrw.org/news/2025/02/03/eu-other-host-states-should-support-syrians-weighing-return-go-and-see-visits> (Accessed 21 Feb. 2025).

¹² Maymi, S. (2024). 'Between "Go-and-See and Come-and-Tell" Visits: Reflections on the Repatriation Decision-Making Process of Rwandan Refugees in Uganda'. *Kujenga Amani*, March 2024 [online]. Available at: <https://kujenga-amani.ssrc.org/2024/03/06/between-go-and-see-and-come-and-tell-visits-reflections-on-the-repatriation-decision-making-process-of-rwandan-refugees-in-uganda/> (Accessed 2 Apr. 2025).

¹³ Hyde, R. (2024). 'Austria offers Syrians £800 to return to homeland'. *The Telegraph*, December 2024 [online]. Available at: <https://www.telegraph.co.uk/world-news/2024/12/13/austria-cash-syrians-return-home-assad/> (Accessed 21 Feb. 2024); Ambri, A. and Barker, H. (2025). 'Statewatch | €1,500 and a one-way ticket: how Cyprus deports Syrian refugees with EU support'. Statewatch.org, February 2024 [online]. Available at: <https://www.statewatch.org/news/2025/february/1-500-and-a-one-way-ticket-how-cyprus-deports-syrian-refugees-with-eu-support/> (Accessed 23 Mar. 2025).

- Advantages: Many Syrian refugees express a desire to return, so facilitating this in an organised manner will stop refugees from facing yet more uncertainty and prevent excessive and sudden pressure on the already limited resources present in Syria. Furthermore, ‘go-and-see’ visits will be relatively simple to implement given that most refugees are hosted in bordering countries (Turkey, Lebanon, Jordan and Iraq)¹⁴.
- Limitations: This policy option relies on collaboration between Syria, these countries and the UNHCR, which will be complicated and require the management of anti-refugee sentiments that place pressure on refugees that seek permanent residence or are undecided in respect to returning to Syria. Furthermore, this process will imply large costs which countries might be unwilling to bear. Finally, “go-and-see” schemes will not always be effective or practical as refugees may feel unsafe even when returning temporarily or elect not to go at all for fear of persecution¹⁵. Logistical difficulties may occur when attempting this with countries like Lebanon, who have political tensions with Syria so may be hostile to these efforts¹⁶.

POLICY RECOMMENDATION

The UNHCR’s main priority should be Policy Option 1, as it will create a solid foundation for the implementation of other, less immediately necessary policies by safeguarding the rights of refugees while they make informed decisions about their future. The scope for improvement of conditions is yet unclear given the live nature of the decisions being taken in Syria surrounding its political path forward, so the UNHCR’s focus should be protecting refugees at risk of forced repatriation or refoulement. Policy Option 2 should follow Option 1, as this will encourage refugees to choose to return by facilitating the creation of safe and stable conditions at home. This will alleviate pressure on host countries, particularly neighbouring host states such as Turkey and Lebanon. Policy Option 3, despite being the clear first choice for most countries, should follow all previous initiatives, as implementing this strategy too early risks prematurely or non-consensually returning, or even refouling, Syrian refugees before the situation awaiting returning refugees in Syria is safe and stable. Therefore, the UNHCR should prioritise pursuit of Policy Option 1, and follow through by implementing Options 2 and 3, in that order.

¹⁴ Chughtai, A. and Ali, M. (2024). ‘Where do six million Syrian refugees live today?’, Al Jazeera, December 2024 [online]. Available at: <https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2024/12/10/where-do-six-million-syrian-refugees-live-today> (Accessed 20 Feb. 2024).

¹⁵ Maymi, S. (2024). ‘Between “Go-and-See and Come-and-Tell” Visits: Reflections on the Repatriation Decision-Making Process of Rwandan Refugees in Uganda’.

¹⁶ Secen, S. (2020). Explaining the Politics of Security: Syrian Refugees in Turkey and Lebanon. *Journal of Global Security Studies*, 6(3). doi:<https://doi.org/10.1093/jogss/ogaa039>.